Tibet, aiming to expand the rail network there to 4,000 km by 2025 from the current 1,400 km. This includes the Xinjiang-Tibet network, which follows the route of the G219 highway passing through Aksai Chin. Also important is the announcement of the construction of the Tibetan Bomi-Ranwu section of the Yunnan-Tibet railway. It will meet the Sichuan-Tibet railway at Bomi and will be extended up to Kunming, capital of Yunnan province. On this line, Nyingchi is just 159 km away from the Indian border. The provinces of Xinjiang, Sichuan and Yunnan are to the north, southeast and south of Tibet respectively. A vast section of the Chinese hinterland will thus be connected by rail to Tibet.

"This line is further integrated with the upcoming wider Tibetan railway network, which runs parallel to the Indian border across Tibet and reaches Hotan in Xinjiang, passing through the disputed Aksai Chin," says an officer in the Indian military establishment. After completion, he adds, the line will reduce the distance from Dali, Kunming, Kaiyuan and Lancang (all in Yunnan) to Tibet. Dali has a PLA mechanised infantry brigade, Kaiyuan and Lancang host infantry brigades and Kunming has infantry, artillery, air defence and armoured brigades. The Tibet-Yunnan railway network will be completed by 2030. The implications on the military situation in Tibet are not lost on anyone.

THE INDIAN RESPONSE

In retaliation to all the Chinese activity, India has beefed up efforts along the LAC in Ladakh as well as along the India-China border in Arunachal Pradesh. It picked up momentum after 2014, as the NDA government took measures to improve strategic infrastructure. Between 2014 and 2020, 14,450 metres of bridges and 4,764 km of border roads were constructed. Much of the road construction near the border with China is taking place under the India-China Border Roads (ICBR) programme. Currently, Phases I and II of ICBR are under way; these involve the construction of 1,435 km of roads, including bridges and tunnels, in Ladakh, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Sikkim and Arunachal Pradesh. Moreover, the government is considering a proposal to build 37 more roads under ICBR-III with a cumulative length of 875 km, much of it in Arunachal. The under-construction 1,800-km-long Frontier Highway, also in Arunachal and named National Highway 913, shadows the China border and connects the China-Bhutan-India border tri-junction to Vijaynagar, via Tawang, Upper Subansari, Siang, Dibang Valley and Kibithu. It is expected to take three years to complete. It will give an unprecedented advantage to the Indian army in terms of response time, accessibility, logistics and reach.

Access to and within Arunachal Pradesh will be further enhanced through the prominent Sela Tunnel road project—at an altitude of over 13,000 feet—that will connect Tawang with Guwahati and the Nechiphu Tunnel on the



A RACE TO SECURE B

CHINA

- Construction, upgradation of 36 airports, and helipads in Tibet and Xinjiang since 2017; extended runways, blast pens in Ngari Burang, Shigatse Tingri, Lhasa-Gonggar airports
- Missile silos and sites, military UAVs, electronic warfare units, frontline fighter jets stationed
- Roads like under-construction Xinjiang-Tibet G695 highway, passing through Aksai Chin, Depsang Plains, Galwan Valley
- Sections of the Tibet-Yunnan railway to be connected to Tibet-Sichuan, Tibet-Xinjiang networks
- Construction of Xiaokang villages near the border



"WELL-DESIGNED BORDER VILLAGES SERVE AS WATCHPOSTS, HELP CHINA IN OCCUPYING NO MAN'S LAND AND REAFFIRM CLAIMS OVER DISPUTED TERRITORIES"

–TSEWANG DORJI
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